THE BUDDHIST HERITAGE OF TAMIL NADU

Although lesser known, there is a wealth of Buddhist heritage and sites in Tamil Nadu waiting to be explored



Tamil Nadu is known for its rich cultural heritage and historical significance. This includes a venerable legacy of Buddhism. While the region is predominantly recognised for its ancient Dravidian temples, it is also home to several hidden gems of Buddhist heritage. Ancient statues of the Buddha have been discovered all over Tamil Nadu and the state was home to various sects of Buddhism like Theravada, Mahayana, Vajrayana. Not only that, many prominent Buddhist scholars hailed from Tamil Nadu like Bodhidharma, Dhammapala, Dharmakirthi and Chandrakirthi.

Buddhism was introduced to Tamil Nadu in the 3rd century BCE during the reign of Emperor Ashoka. Ashoka's Rock Edict II mentions that the Chola, Pandiya and Keralaputra dynasties ruled the region at the time and the places where he sent Buddhist missionaries. The early traces of Buddhism can be discerned from the presence of Brahmi script, which was popularised by Ashoka, in several caves of Madurai, Tiruchirappalli, Tirunelveli and Chengalpattu districts.

Buddhism flourished in Tamil Nadu in two prominent timelines. The first was 400–650 AD, which marked the early years of Pallava rule. The second was the mid-9th to early 14th century AD. This is the period when the Chola dynasty held sway over the region. By the 16th century, with the rise of Shaivism and the Bhakti movement, Buddhism had faded away from the region. However, traces of Tamil Nadu's Buddhist heritage can still be seen. Kancheepuram, Madurai, Kaveripoompattinam (now known as Poompuhar), Woraiyur (a neighborhood of Tiruchirappalli), and Nagapattinam were among the significant Buddhist hubs in Tamil Nadu.

Exploring the enchanting Buddhist sites of Tamil Nadu is an experience that leaves the visitors with a deeper understanding of the historical, artistic, and spiritual impact of Buddhism in South India.These serene and captivating Buddhist sites offer a glimpse into the profound influence of Buddhism in Tamil Nadu's history.

Kancheepuram

Kancheepuram was once one of the largest Buddhist centres in South India, especially in the second half of the first millennium CE. The accounts of several travellers attest to this. The Chinese scholar Xuanzang found Kancheepuram to be a bustling city with a majority Buddhist population. According to him, there were over 100 Buddhist monasteries here, where thousands of Buddhist monks resided. Bodhidharma, one of the eminents who hailed from Kancheepuram Tamil Nadu, was instrumental in spreading Buddhism in China. Once a Pallava Prince, he gave up his royal life at an early age and devoted himself to religious pursuits. The Pallava king Mahendra Varman in his Sanskrit work 'MattavilasaPrahasana' also alludes to the presence of many Buddhist viharas here.

Kancheepuram rose in prominence as a Buddhist centre when Poompuhar, the earlier centre, got submerged into the sea. A lot of Buddhist statues and artifacts have been found in Kancheepuram. As per Vajrayana Buddhism, Kanchi is one of the 24 most sacred places of the dakini. Some ancient Buddha statues from Kancheepuram can be viewed at the Chennai Museum.

